

DELVE DEEP

Chronological town-and-delve progression inspired by the Heroes of the Lance

Design goal: follow the broad journey of the Heroes of the Lance through the Chronicles and classic DL modules, then turn that geography into a playable sequence of separate towns and delves. The party splits after Tarsis, so the two branches are preserved as player-choice arcs rather than forced into a single canonical route.

Act I - Abanasinia and the Lost Gods

TOWN: Solace - Opening hub: Inn of the Last Home, familiar NPCs, rumors, supplies, and the first signs of invasion.

DELVE 1: Que-Shu approaches and occupied roads - Introductory hostile travel zone with patrols, ruins, clues, and escalating danger.

DELVE 2: Darken Wood - A wilderness delve of spectral threats, magical guardians, and the Forestmaster.

TOWN: Haven / Plains settlements - A civilized resupply stop and information hub before the first major ruin.

DELVE 3: Xak Tsaroth - upper ruins - Swamp approaches, broken plazas, draconians, and the first descent.

DELVE 4: Xak Tsaroth - Temple of Mishakal - Sacred ruins and the recovery of the Disks of Mishakal.

DELVE 5: Xak Tsaroth - lower city and dragon lair - Major boss delve centered on Khisanth and the buried city.

TOWN UNLOCK: Solace, changed by occupation - Return to a familiar location transformed by the war.

Act II - Qualinesti and Pax Tharkas

DELVE 6: Occupied Solace / slave caravan route - Infiltration, rescue, ambushes, and travel through enemy-held territory.

TOWN: Qualinost - Major elven hub: politics, allies, equipment, and planning for Pax Tharkas.

DELVE 7: Sla-Mori - Ancient secret passage with tombs, forgotten history, and hidden routes.

DELVE 8: Pax Tharkas - fortress - Barracks, towers, chambers, prisons, and occupied stronghold exploration.

DELVE 9: Pax Tharkas - mines and dragon areas - Deeper industrial spaces, captives, and draconic threats.

TOWN UNLOCK: Freed refugee camp - Clearing Pax Tharkas creates a new hub of refugees, merchants, craftspeople, and quest-givers.

Act III - The Dwarven Depths

DELVE 10: Kharolis Mountains - Caves, abandoned routes, pursuit, weather, and dwarven remnants.

DELVE 11: Abandoned dwarven outpost / Aghar territory - A smaller dungeon-scale stop drawn from the module journey.

DELVE 12: Dergoth Plain - Outdoor haunted delve built around the scars of the Dwarfgate War.

DELVE 13: Skullcap - outer fortress - The shattered magical fortress and its dangerous entrances.

DELVE 14: Skullcap - deep levels - Undead, traps, magical history, and the knowledge needed to reach Thorbardin.

TOWN UNLOCK: Thorbardin - Skullcap reveals the route into the sealed dwarven kingdom.

DELVE 15: Thorbardin contested halls - Factional dwarves, ancient infrastructure, and dangerous internal districts.

DELVE 16: Floating Tomb of Derkin - Self-contained dwarven tomb and capstone dungeon.

TOWN: Thorbardin secured - A major underground hub with crafting, trade, refugees, and new routes.

Act IV - Tarsis and Icewall

TOWN: Tarsis - Large city hub immediately destabilized by the Dragonarmy attack.

DELVE 17: Fall of Tarsis - A city turned into a disaster dungeon: fires, collapsing districts, troops, rescues, and escape.

DELVE 18: Ice Reaches - Glacial wilderness delve with crevasses, survival hazards, and buried paths.

TOWN: Ice Folk camp - Small cultural hub before Icewall.

DELVE 19: Icewall approach and hidden tunnel - Avalanche, ascent, and secret access to the fortress.

DELVE 20: Icewall Castle - Frozen fortress dungeon and Dragon Orb objective.

TOWN: Icemountain Bay / ship refuge - Transition hub opening sea travel.

Act V - Southern Ergoth and the Knights

DELVE 21: Thunder Bay shipwreck - Salvage-and-survival opening on Southern Ergoth.

TOWN: Elven refugee settlements - Tense hub involving Kagonesti, Qualinesti, and Silvanesti factions.

DELVE 22: Ergoth wild lands - Forests, ruins, patrols, and routes toward Foghaven.

DELVE 23: Castle Foghaven - Compact ruined castle and staging site.

DELVE 24: Stone Dragon / Tomb of Huma - Heroic tomb delve tied to the secret of the Dragonlances.

TOWN UNLOCK: Sancrist / Whitestone Council - Dragonlance discoveries lead into the organized resistance.

TOWN: Sancrist and Mount Nevermind - Knights, gnomes, politics, upgrades, and war preparation.

DELVE 25: High Clerist's Tower - lower fortress - Huge ancient defensive complex suited to a multi-floor delve.

DELVE 26: High Clerist's Tower - secret and upper levels - Forgotten purpose, traps, Dragon Orb, and climactic defense.

TOWN UNLOCK: Palanthas - Victory opens the great city as a late-game metropolitan hub.

Act VI - The Silvanesti Nightmare (parallel branch)

DELVE 27: Approach to Silvanesti - Dangerous travel and transition into the corrupted elven realm.

DELVE 28: The Bleeding Forest - The forest itself becomes a nightmare dungeon with dreamlike geography.

DELVE 29: Silvanost - An entire capital functioning as an urban nightmare delve.

DELVE 30: Palace of Quinari / heart of the nightmare - Boss layer and source of the magical corruption.

TOWN UNLOCK: Restored Silvanesti enclave - A hostile delve partially transforms back into a sanctuary.

Act VII - Flotsam and the Blood Sea

TOWN: Flotsam - Enemy-held port with spies, taverns, ships, soldiers, and criminal contacts.

DELVE 31: Flotsam infiltration sites - Warehouses, compounds, alleys, and enemy facilities as short urban delves.

DELVE 32: Blood Sea - Nautical delve made of storms, monsters, reefs, and supernatural hazards.

DELVE 33: The Maelstrom - Major traversal hazard and threshold to the world below.

DELVE 34: Sunken Istar - outer ruins - Submerged streets and ancient architecture.

DELVE 35: Sunken Istar - inner city - Deeper pre-Cataclysm ruins and sacred spaces.

TOWN UNLOCK: Undersea refuge - Temporary exotic hub earned by surviving the drowned city.

Act VIII - Into the Dragon Empire

TOWN: Kalaman / allied war hub - Armies, intelligence, equipment, and preparation for the final push.

DELVE 36: Occupied Dragon Empire - Forts, checkpoints, ruined villages, and war camps.

DELVE 37: Dark Passages - Secret routes beneath or through enemy defenses.

DELVE 38: Glitterpalace - Supernatural test-delve focused on choices and character trials.

DELVE 39: Dargaard Keep - Optional gothic late-game fortress with Lord Soth and undead knights.

TOWN: Neraka outer city - Final hostile hub: disguises, factions, merchants, pilgrims, soldiers, and spies.

DELVE 40: Neraka Undercity - Sewers, caverns, catacombs, and tunnels beneath the capital.

DELVE 41: Temple of Takhisis - lower and main levels - The final fortress-temple begins below ground and rises through ceremonial spaces.

DELVE 42: Temple of Takhisis - upper levels and Gate - Campaign finale and confrontation at the Dark Queen's gate.

Suggested campaign cadence

The numbered sites do not all need to be full megadungeons. Treat most as short one-to-three-floor delves or wilderness/urban expeditions, and make every fourth or fifth site a major dungeon. The strongest major-delve candidates are Xak Tsaroth, Pax Tharkas, Skullcap, the Floating Tomb, Icewall Castle, the Tomb of Huma, High Clerist's Tower, Silvanost, Sunken Istar, Dargaard Keep, and the Temple of Takhisis.

Best unlock pattern: Skullcap -> Thorbardin is the clearest example of clearing a delve to gain a town. Pax Tharkas -> refugee camp, Tomb of Huma -> Sancrist/Whitestone, High Clerist's Tower -> Palanthis, and the Silvanesti nightmare -> restored enclave can use the same structure.

Chronology and source spine

Core novel spine: *Dragons of Autumn Twilight* -> *Dragons of Winter Night* -> *Dragons of Spring Dawning*. Module expansion spine: DL1 *Dragons of Despair*, DL2 *Dragons of Flame*, DL3 *Dragons of Hope*, DL4 *Dragons of Desolation*, DL6 *Dragons of Ice*, DL7 *Dragons of Light*, DL8 *Dragons of War*, DL10 *Dragons of Dreams*, DL12 *Dragons of Faith*, DL13 *Dragons of Truth*, and DL14 *Dragons of Triumph*.

Important: This is deliberately a campaign-design synthesis. Not every Hero personally visits every location in this exact sequence. The original party splits, reunites, and the modules expand events the novels sometimes summarize or omit. For *Delve Deep*, that is useful: the split can simply become a route choice offered to the player.